Figure Out What Coordinating Mom's Care Would Actually Involve

Four prompts to gather what you already know about Mom's doctors, papers, and helpers, picture the tasks a coordinator would carry, see which family members could learn alongside each other, and note what would have to be updated when care actually begins.

Where you are

Mom runs her own life. She drives, keeps her own appointments, and would be annoyed if you suggested otherwise. You've watched a friend get buried when a parent's care arrived all at once, and you'd rather learn the basics while there is nothing to coordinate.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can describe the tasks that coordinating Mom's care would involve, name two people in the family who could learn them together, and list what you'd need to find out before any of it was real.

A one-page starter sheet with headings: What we know now, Tasks a coordinator would carry, Who could practice together, and What we'd have to update when care begins.

Before you start

- A rough list of Mom's doctors, pharmacy, and any regular appointments.
- Where her important papers live, even if the answer is 'somewhere in the den.'
- The names of relatives who might be involved later. You don't need agreement from any of them yet.

PROMPT 1

Gather what you already know

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most of what a coordinator needs on day one is information the family half knows and nobody has written down. Collecting it while Mom can simply tell you is the easiest version of this task you will ever get.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Whatever you know about her doctors, pharmacy, insurance, papers, and the people in her life.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My mother is well and manages her own affairs. I want to learn how care coordination works before anyone in my family needs to do it. Here is what I already know about her doctors, pharmacy, insurance, important papers, and the people in her life:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Organize this into a table with three columns: WHAT WE KNOW, WHERE IT LIVES OR WHO HAS IT, and HOW SURE I AM. For anything I only half know, write 'ask her' or 'look it up' in the last column instead of filling in a guess. Do not add anything I didn't tell you.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How much of this lives in one person's head, usually Mom's.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask her the two easiest questions over coffee, and keep it light.

PROMPT 2

Picture the tasks a coordinator would carry

WHY THIS MATTERS

Care coordination sounds like a profession. Broken into its pieces, a lot of it looks like things people already do at work or at home, and some of it is genuinely new.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Nothing new; this prompt gives you a plain description to react to.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I want to understand what coordinating my mother's care would involve someday, in plain terms. Here are the kinds of tasks I've heard a care coordinator handles: keeping the current plan and documents where everyone can find them, preparing for meetings with providers, tracking a concern until someone answers it, keeping a short log of what was noticed, and knowing which professional to call for which issue.
>
> For each one, write two or three sentences on what the task looks like in an ordinary week. Then give me a table with the task in one column and, in the next, a question I could ask myself about whether anyone in my family has done something like it already, at work or at home. Do not tell me we need a coordinator or recommend a service.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Tasks that resemble things you already do, such as keeping records at work, and tasks that are genuinely new to everyone.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Answer the questions in the second column honestly, for yourself and for one other relative.

PROMPT 3

Find a practice partner

WHY THIS MATTERS

The sibling who lives closest tends to become the coordinator by default, and then the only one who knows how anything works. Learning in pairs is the simplest protection against that.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A list of relatives, roughly where they live, how much time they have, and what they tend to take on.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the people in my family who might be involved in my mother's care someday, with where they live, how much time they usually have, and what they tend to take on:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> I don't want one person to end up holding everything. Using only what I wrote, make a table: each person, what they already tend to handle, and which of the coordination tasks from my earlier list might fit them. Then suggest two or three pairs who could practice a task together, and point out any task where I named only one possible person. Treat these as conversation starters, not assignments. Do not pick a lead coordinator.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Pairs you hadn't considered, and the tasks that have only one name beside them.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Send the table to one relative and ask what they'd change; their edits are the point.

PROMPT 4

Put it on one page, with a note about what would change

WHY THIS MATTERS

A planning document that nobody revisits quietly goes wrong. The useful version says, on its own face, what would need checking before anyone relied on it.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've put together about how my family might coordinate my mother's care someday:
>
> [PASTE EVERYTHING FROM PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write one page with four headings: WHAT WE KNOW NOW, TASKS A COORDINATOR WOULD CARRY, WHO COULD PRACTICE TOGETHER, and WHAT WE'D HAVE TO UPDATE WHEN CARE BEGINS. Under the last heading, list the items on this page that would go stale or need checking if my mother's situation changed, such as contacts, documents, and who is available. Mark the whole page 'practice copy, not for active use' at the top. Do not write a care plan or a playbook, and do not suggest that care is needed now.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page the family could pick up in two years and know exactly what to check first.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Put a reminder in your calendar to re-read the page in six months, then stop; there's nothing more to do today.

Give the practice something real to stand on.

Practice goes better with real information. The care interview gathers Mom's situation area by area into a Family Care Profile, so when the family rehearses, it is working from her actual doctors, papers, and routines rather than a blank form.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›